

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

A TEST OF TWO CMs

The assembly elections in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh have also turned the spotlight on the poll minders of the Congress for the two states—Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot and his Chhattisgarh counterpart Bhupesh Baghel. Baghel had been assigned election duty in Assam and Uttar Pradesh too, but could not help bolster the party's tally. Gehlot, by contrast, helped the Gujarat Congress see its best-ever performance in decades in 2017 in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's home state, giving the BJP a real scare. Results day—December 8—could now determine the stature of both CMs, especially with party rebels snapping at their heels in their respective home states.

GUJARAT MODEL?



When the BJP dropped 38 sitting MLAs in its first list of candidates for the assembly election in Gujarat, the reverberations were felt in faraway Karnataka. The southern state goes to the polls in May 2023 and the state BJP desperately needs an image makeover. So, when **Lahar Singh Siroya,** the Rajya Sabha member from the state, tweeted that the Gujarat approach of senior leaders making way for youngsters "should serve as a model in Karnataka too", it set off tremors in the BJP camp.



ANI

Chacha-bhatija Season

On November 9, as Bihar chief minister **Nitish Kumar** held Rashtriya Janata Dal leader **Tejashwi Yadav** in a tight hug at a state event, he appealed to all present to wish the deputy CM on his birthday. With "*chacha-bhatija*" bonhomie being the flavour of the season, rapprochement seems to be on the cards for another duo—the estranged Pashupati Kumar Paras and Chirag Paswan, both claimants to the late Ram Vilas Paswan's legacy. Especially as Chirag is now back in the BJP's good books and uncle Paras is in the cabinet.



Delete Button

With the Uttar Pradesh police recently filing an FIR against Kanpur University vice-chancellor **Vinay Kumar Pathak**, netas of every hue are deleting photos with him from their social media accounts. Given that Pathak has held the post for several years, he was well known for his political connections. Charged with bribery, corruption, extortion and even illegal confinement, government sources say that Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath himself has asked for Pathak's file and a probe into his political network. But nobody is asking the big question yet: who was protecting the tainted V-C till now?

NOT SO SWEET



On November 7, West Bengal panchayat minister **Pradip Majumdar** finally got an appointment with the Union minister of rural development and panchayati raj **Giriraj Singh** after waiting for months. The purpose: to get funds released for the MNREGA 100 days' work scheme, which the Centre had halted, citing "gross misappropriation". Majumdar had gone with the choicest *nolen-gur* (winter jaggery) sweets and apparently Giriraj went ga-ga over them, even discussing the prospects of Bengal exporting jaggery. But on the release of funds, he begged off. No sweetener for Majumdar, it seems.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Kaushik Deka *with* ***Ajay Sukumaran, Amitabh Srivastava, Romita Datta and Prashant Srivastava***